FIFTEEN

GOING OVER-THE-COUNTER

IN EARLY MARCH, THE STOCK MARKET WAS ON THE RISE, AND SO were my options. I bought them on February 21 and cashed them two weeks later for a delightful profit of $400. For this, I was grateful to the astrologer and his electrical beings.

Although I could have returned to Mr. Crawford and purchased more options on his latest advice, I sensed that enough was enough. An evening with Mr. Gressel, a professional trader, convinced me that I'd been in over my head, since even he didn't seem to know if he was winning or losing from one day to the next. I figured I'd had beginner's luck, and so I quit while I was ahead. It seemed more sensible to stick with simple stocks, about which I was relatively well informed.

Unfortunately, the price of Angstrom shares had dropped even further, causing me to lose as much or more than the $400 I'd made on the options in the same period. Though the mottoes "Be Patient" and "Don't Sell Too Soon" had inspired me to hold on, I'd begun to suspect that I should have paid closer attention to "It's Never Too Soon to Sell and Cut Your Losses." Frankly, I couldn't tolerate owning this Angstrom any more than you can tolerate hearing about it. The stories about the big government contract soon-to-be-signed and the infighting soon-to-be-resolved were beginning to sound unlikely.

Before taking any drastic action, though, I wanted to meet some people directly involved in the stock, to get their learned advice. Angstrom, I knew, was sold over-the-counter. Perhaps I could get to see an Angstrom specialist—but where was this counter? I'd assumed it had to be someplace around Wall Street, but that turned out to be false. I asked several ignorant pedestrians on Wall Street